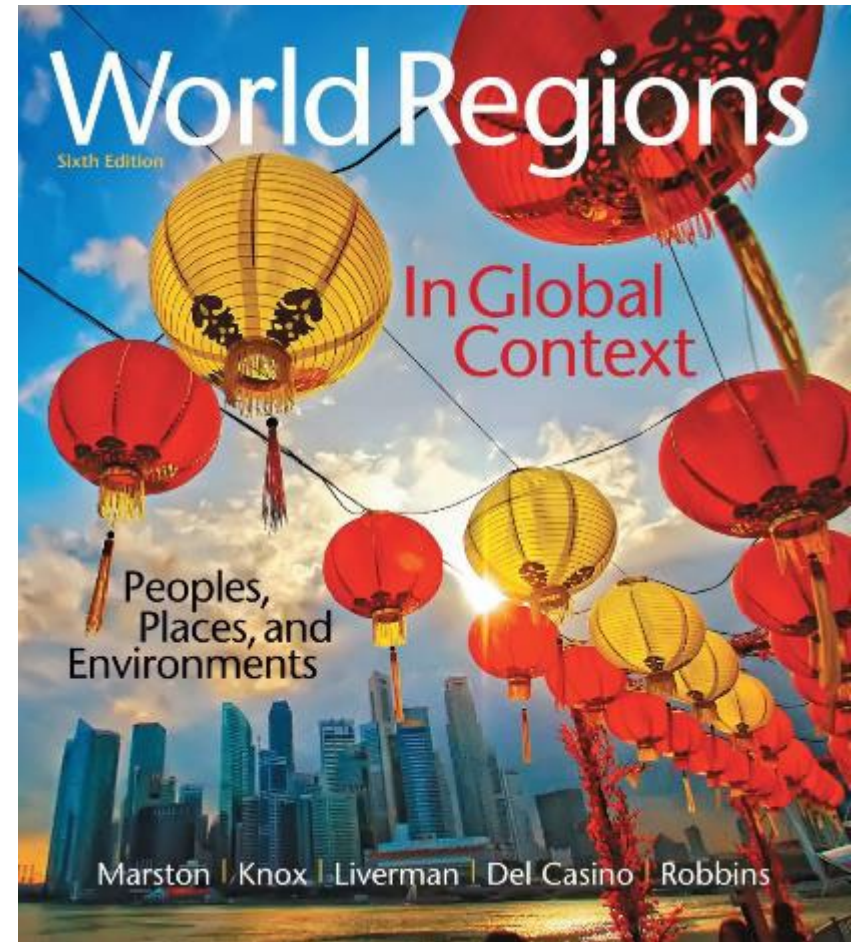


World Regions in Global Context: Peoples, Places, and Environments

6th Edition

The Russian Federation, Central Asia, and the Transcaucasus

Lectures by:
Christa Ann Smith



Learning Outcomes

- Describe the physical geography of the Russian Federation, Central Asia, and the Transcaucasus Region.
- Predict how climate change and environmental impacts of human activities may influence the region's future sustainability.
- Explain how people have adapted to and modified the physical landscapes in this world region.

Learning Outcomes

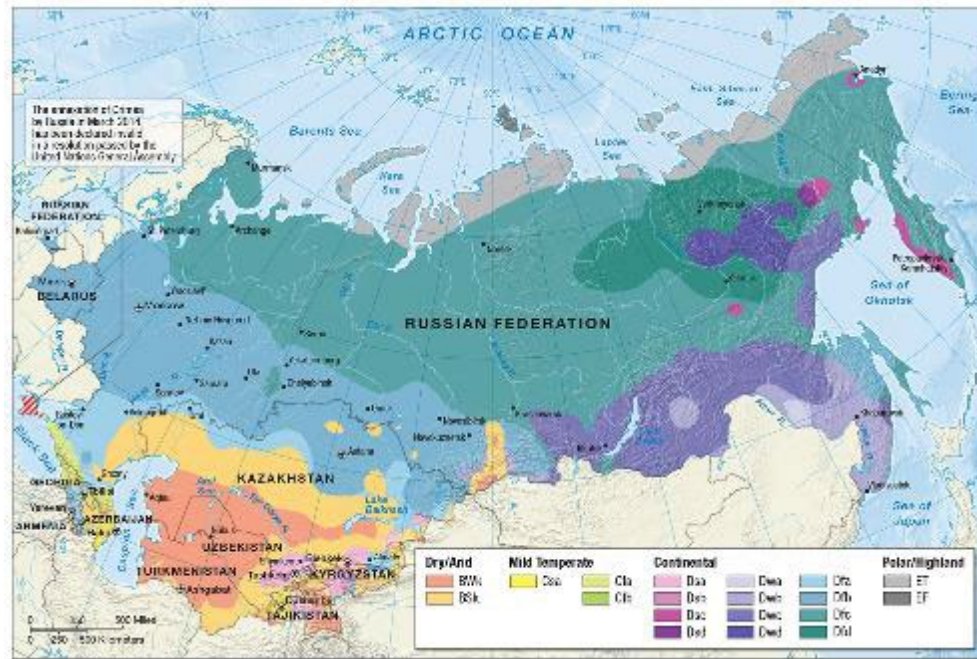
- Describe how economic transitions in the region are playing out in the post-Socialist era.
- Analyze the changing political trends in the region in terms of fragmentation and realignment.
- Summarize the cultural legacies and new developments in the region in terms of high, revolutionary, and popular forms of culture.
- Discuss and analyze the implications of demographic change in the region.

Environment, Society, and Sustainability

- Vast territory, sparsely populated
 - Borders: Eastern Europe, the Arctic, and the Pacific Ocean
 - Southern borders: Middle East, South Asia, and East Asia
-
- The map displays the Russian Federation, highlighting its extensive landmass and strategic borders. Key features include:
- Geographical Features:** The Arctic Ocean to the north, the Barents Sea, Kara Sea, Laptev Sea, and East Siberian Sea to the northeast, and the Pacific Ocean to the east.
 - Major Cities:** Moscow (the capital), St. Petersburg, and Yekaterinburg are marked as metropolitan areas with populations between 5-9.9 million. Other cities like Novosibirsk and Khabarovsk are also indicated.
 - Administrative Regions:** The map shows various federal subjects, including the Republic of Dagestan, Chechnya, and Ingushetia.
 - Geopolitical Context:** The map illustrates Russia's borders with Eastern Europe, the Arctic, and the Pacific Ocean, as well as its southern borders with the Middle East, South Asia, and East Asia.



Climate and Climate Change



- Four major climate zones
 1. Arid
 2. Semiarid
 3. Continental/Midlatitude
 4. Polar
 - permafrost

Adapting to a Warming Continent and Melting Sea Ice

- Climate change: positive affects
 - milder winters in the northern latitudes
 - longer growing seasons
 - increased water availability
- Climate change: negative affects
 - melting of permafrost
 - heat waves/increased forest fires
 - geopolitical implications

Geological Resources, Risk, and Water

- Physiographic regions



Geological Resources, Risk, and Water (cont.)

- Plains
 - geologically stable
 - agricultural heartland
 - Russia's major rivers
 - marshy, poorly drained areas
 - oil and gas reserves



Geological Resources, Risk, and Water (cont.)

- Mountains
 - highest range: Caucasus Mountains
 - Urals
 - mineral wealth
 - industrial cities
 - mountain rim
 - geologic instability: earthquakes and volcanoes
- Central Asia
 - **geosyncline**
 - oil reserves
 - gas reserves

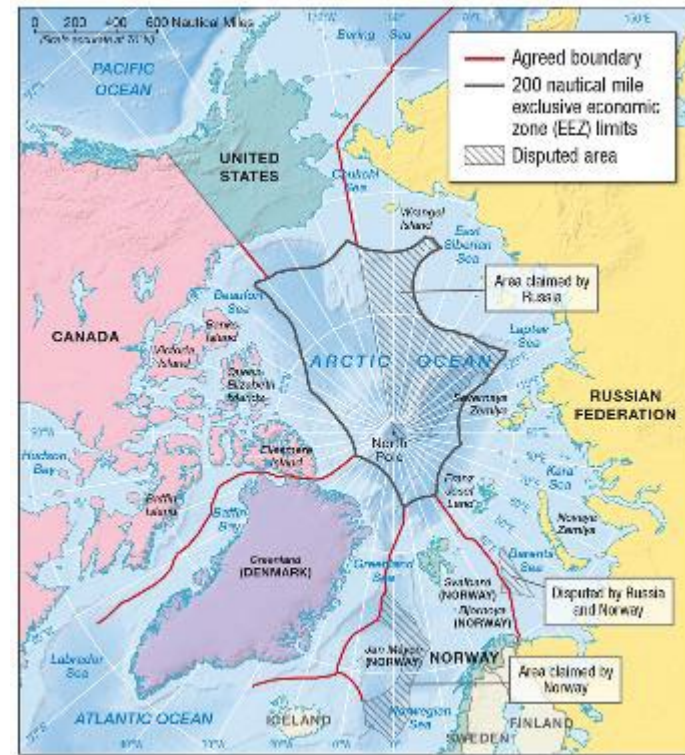
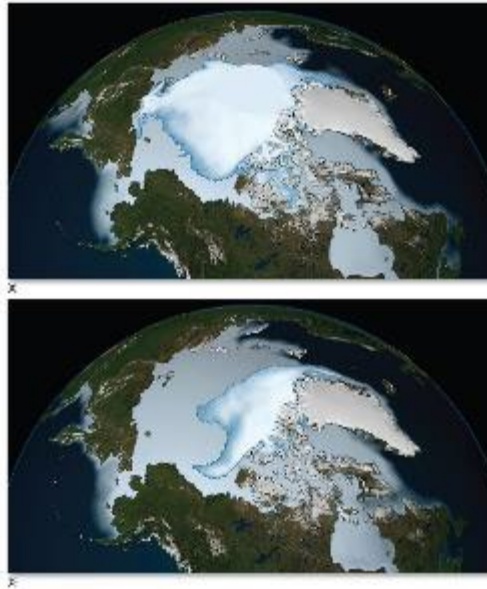
Geological Resources, Risk, and Water (cont.)

- Rivers
 - Lena
 - Ob'
 - Amur
- Seas/Lakes
 - Caspian Sea
 - Black Sea
 - Lake Baykal



The Arctic

- Northwest Passage
 - global trade
- Global climate change
 - new commercial routes
 - access to seafloor
 - negative impact on wildlife
 - geopolitical ramifications



(a)

Ecology, Land, and Environmental Management

- Five zones
 - climate patterns
- **Tundra**
 - most northerly
 - arctic wilderness
 - winters: weak daylight; snow
 - summers: long days; bogs and marshes
 - indigenous peoples
 - reindeer herders



Ecology, Land, and Environmental Management (cont.)

- **Taiga**

- most extensive zone
- coniferous forest
- spruce, fir, and pine
- fur-bearing animals

- **Mixed forest**

- large-scale logging operations
- **privatization** of timber industry
- environmental concern



Ecology, Land, and Environmental Management (cont.)

- **Steppe**
 - flat grassland
 - limited rainfall
 - cleared for agriculture
 - wheat belt
 - corn and cotton



Ecology, Land, and Environmental Management (cont.)

- Semidesert and desert
 - Central Asia
 - salt pans
 - **nomadic pastoralists**
 - extensive sand dunes
 - scattered oasis and a few fertile valleys

Challenges to Sustainability in the Region

- Over-exploitation of Aral Sea
- Pollution of rivers and lakes
- Increased hazards of summer fires
- Offshore oil drilling threatens marine ecosystems



Furs

- 15 billion global retail sales
- Status symbol and luxury item
- Controversy
 - extinction
 - fur farming
- Activism
- Fashion comeback



Historical Legacies and Landscapes

- **Silk Road**

- Central Asia
 - connected China and the Mediterranean
- Samarkand
 - center of mathematics, music, and Islamic architecture
 - **khans**, nomadic people in the region



The Rise of the Russian Empire

- Principality of Muscovy
 - centered around the city of Moscow
 - in 1552, Ivan the Terrible freed Muscovy from the Tatars
 - steady expansion of Russian dominance
 - **tsars** (rulers of Russian empire)



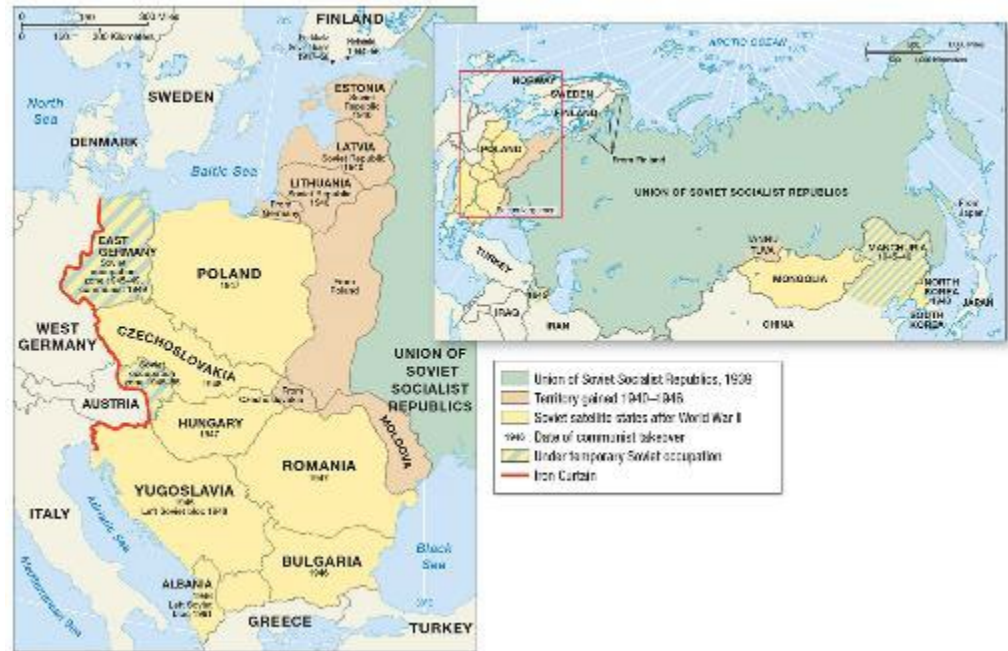
The Rise of the Russian Empire (cont.)

- Early 20th century:
severe depression
- **Soviets** formed in
protest
 - discontent
- World War I further put
tsars in disfavor
- October 1917
 - **Bolshevik** Revolution
 - Soviet Union established



The Rise of the Russian Empire (cont.)

- **State socialism**
 - people's compliance
- **Lenin**
 - internationalist
 - **Union of Soviet Socialist Republics**
- **Stalin**
 - anti-nationalism
 - expansion into Eastern Europe
 - **command economy**
 - severe repression
 - **collectivization**



The Rise of the Russian Empire (cont.)

- Growth
 - territorial production complexes
 - industrialization of less-developed subregions
 - “secret cities”
- Cold War
 - 1950–1989
 - communism challenged the dominance of capitalism (the United States)
 - proxy conflicts



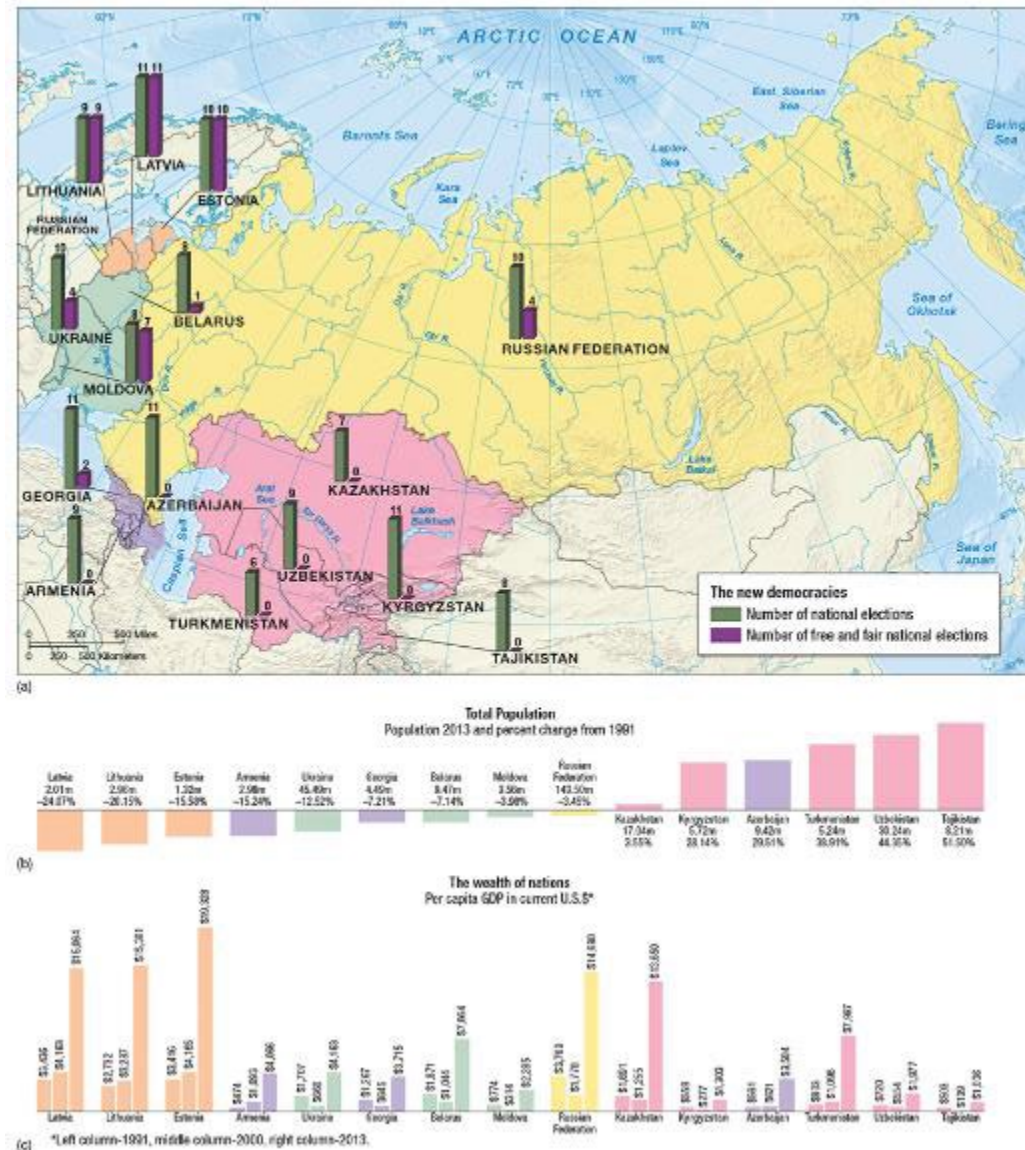
The Rise of the Russian Empire (cont.)

- Soviet Union in crisis by 1980
 - failure to deliver consumer goods
 - population was becoming informed of consumerism elsewhere
 - regional inequities
 - economic drain of the arms race
 - inflexibility and lack of computer technology
 - between 1989 and 1991, the Soviet Union broke apart into 15 independent states



Economy, Accumulation, and the Production of Inequality

- Shift to capitalism after 70 years of central planning has been problematic
- **Mafiyas** (organized crime groups)
- **Oligarchs**
- Economic growth dramatic between 2000 and 2014
- End of 2013, Russia 9th largest economy in the world



Economy, Accumulation, and the Production of Inequality (cont.)

- The Central Region
 - centered on Moscow
 - 85% urban
 - major contributor to Russian Federation production
- Regions of decreasing prosperity
 - regions of territorial conflict
 - resource-poor regions



Territory and Politics

- 27 million non-Russians
- Chechen independence
 - Sunni Muslims
 - Soviet treatment of Chechens
 - **glasnost**
 - 1989 declaration of independence
 - Russian invasion in 1994
 - fall of Grozny in 2000



Territory and Politics (cont.)

- Transcaucasia and Central Asia
- **Ethnonationalism**
 - Nagorno-Karabakh
 - Armenian citizens of Azerbaijan
 - civil war
 - oil pipeline
 - South Ossetia
 - Georgia
 - Tajikistan
 - civil war
 - Fergana Valley
 - Uzbekistan



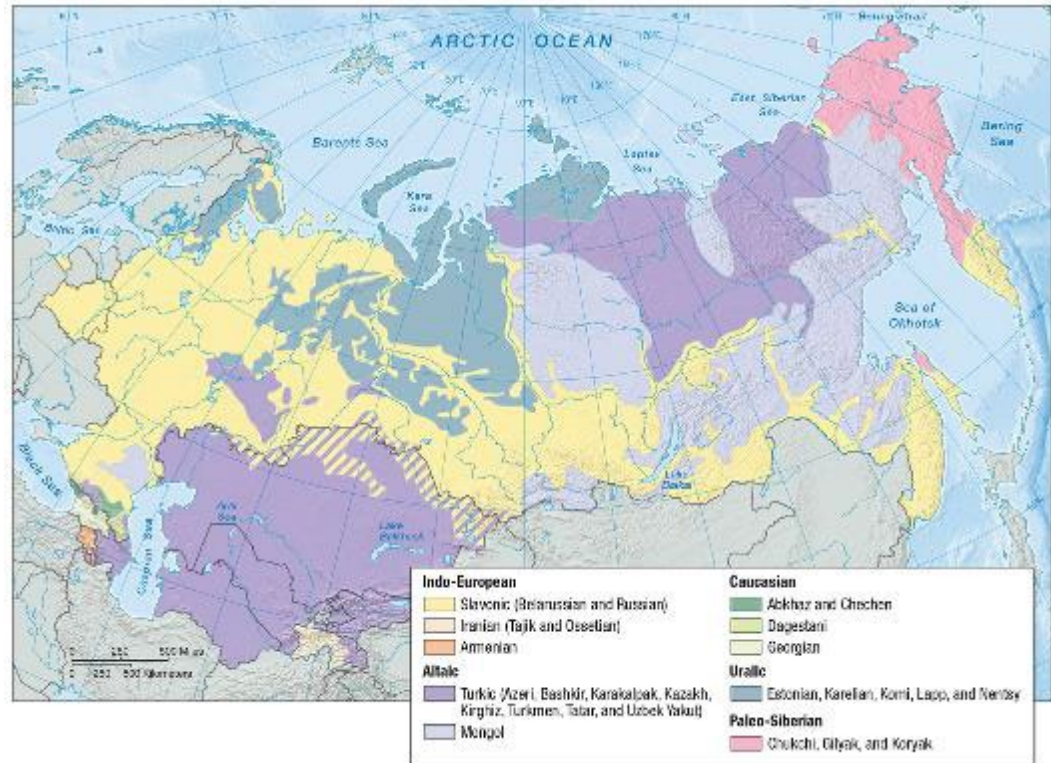
Territory and Politics (cont.)

- Geopolitical shifts
 - **Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS)**
 - **Near Abroad**
 - Russia's expanding political influence
 - civil society
 - pluralist democracy
 - BRICS



Religion and Language

- Religion
 - Eastern Orthodoxy
 - Russia and Georgia
 - Islam
 - Azerbaijan and Central Asia
- Language
 - Slavonic
 - Turkic
 - Paleo-Siberian
 - Caucasian



Cultural Practices, Social Differences, and Identity

- High culture
 - influenced by European art
 - classical music, ballet, novels, and poetry
- Popular culture
 - influenced by the Soviet era
 - influenced by the West
 - food traditions
 - modern Art



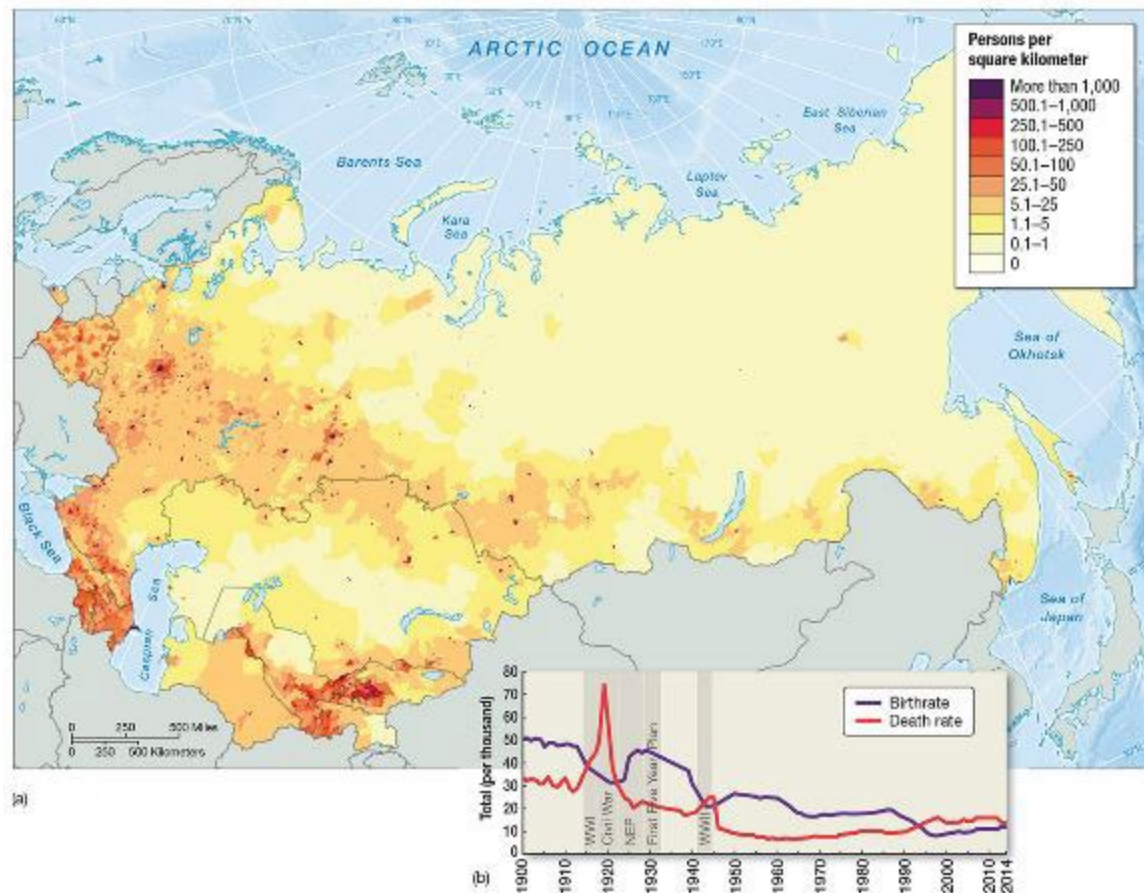
Gender and Inequality

- Gender and identity
 - Soviet era
 - new opportunities
 - legally off-limits jobs
 - wage disparity
 - regressed political representation



Demography and Urbanization

- Low population density
- Higher urbanization in Russia
- Population growth and decline
 - slow-growing population
 - higher birthrates in Central Asia
 - rising mortality rates among men



Future Geographies

- Energy dependency
- Democracy and plutocracy
 - elites as sources of corruption
- Far East economic boom
- Demographic implosion?
 - aging population



End of Chapter 3